DCU Faculty of Engineering & Computing (FEC)
FACULTY RESEARCH ETHICS COMMITTEE (F-REC)

SELF DECLARATION FORM FOR ETHICAL REVIEW OF A NOTIFICATION ONLY RESEARCH PROJECT INVOLVING HUMAN PARTICIPANTS

There are 3 generally accepted levels of ethical review for projects carried out in a University or similar setting. These are notification only, expediated and full committee.

This notification only level of review is to approve relatively low-risk research involving human participants, primarily using social science methodologies in which any personal information collected is not of a sensitive nature. The School of Computing Research Ethics Committee has been delegated responsibility by the University to approve ethics submissions from undergraduate and taught Masters projects only, which are in the category of notification only.

Examples of projects in this category include:

- Anonymous surveys in which the topic itself is not likely to elicit significant difficulties for the participants, such as: anonymous internet surveys (e.g. Survey Monkey), street questioning.
- Observation (without audio or visual recording) of public settings where privacy would not normally be expected, such as observing people on streets or at sports events.
- Research carrying no risks beyond those of everyday life (as experienced by the intended participant population), such as asking people's opinions about products or services; asking students about educational experiences; monitoring the impact of daily activities.
- Interviews with public figures, professionals or others in their professional capacity regarding their professional activities.
- Analysis of data (e.g. health records) which have had all identifying information removed by the data holder and been provided to the researcher in accordance with data protection legislation.
- Collection of biological samples which are anonymised and do not require invasive techniques (e.g. hair, nails).

If, for whatever reason, you cannot confirm adherence to the requirements listed below you must complete the Notification only application form.

By completing this form, you confirm the following:

- That you plan to perform an anonymous user study where participants will be asked to answer questions about their experience using your developed application and to provide general feedback and/or suggestions to improve this application.
- That your user study will take participants no more than ten minutes to complete.

- That your project **does NOT** involve the collection of data from the following special categories of participants:
    - Children under the age of 18
    - Persons in unequal relationships with the researcher (e.g. lecturer-student, therapist-client, employer-employee)
    - People with a recognised or diagnosed intellectual, physical or mental impairment
    - People confined to institutions (e.g. prisoners, residents in 24 hr nursing facilities)
    - People who have undergone traumatic or adverse emotional events
    - People with diminished cognitive ability
    - Marginalised sections of society
    - Any other persons who may be considered vulnerable for the purpose of this study

- Data will be collected within the Republic of Ireland and will require no additional permissions to access participants.
- The project has not been submitted to another research ethics committee for review.
- There is no direct or indirect benefits to participants by taking part in the research
- Appropriate measures have been taken to minimise potential risks and harms to participants. Any risks identified as being posed by this work should not be greater than that of using any application in a standard day-to-day setting.
- This research is not externally funded.
- Participants were not offered any incentive in order to participate in the research
- The research raises no risks for the researchers themselves
- The research raises no conflict of interest
- In the event of unexpected outcomes or adverse affects to participants, the user study will be ended and reported to the investigator's supervisor immediately.
- The conduct of the research will be monitored by your project supervisor
- That personal data is not collected as part of the project
- That no identifiable personal information is collected as part of the project
- That no Special Categories of personal data is collected as part of the project
- That only data in which the topic itself is not likely to elicit significant difficulties for the participants is collected as part of the project
- That the investigators named on the form have completed the DCU Data Protection training module on Loop
- That the investigators have read the "Data Protection – Key Points for DCU Researchers" guidance on the DCU Data Protection Unit (DPU) website and agree to protect and manage our data in accordance with same.
- That the investigators named on the form confirm they have assessed the degree of risk inherent in the personal data being used in the research project, and confirm that all DPU GDPR requirements have been met prior to submitting this application *(e.g. completion of Data Protection questionnaire, confirmation that any survey tool being used is GDPR compliant, that required Data Processing or Sharing Agreements will be in place, etc.)*
- The data collected is confined to the investigators named on the application
- Appropriate steps have been taken to store collected data securely
    - Data collected on mobile devices will be protected with a strong password/passphrase at a minimum, and/or encrypted if the device supports it
    - Data will be removed from mobile devices as soon as is practicable and stored in a secured location in DCU (on server or institutional Google Drive)

    - Paper based data will be held securely in locked cabinets in DCU, with access restricted to the named researchers
- The investigators named on this form are responsible for the secure storage of data generated by the research
- The data will be held until the end of the project, which will be no longer than the first day of teaching for semester one following that date on this form. Data no longer being held will be destroyed. At the end of the project the data will be destroyed by the investigators named on this form as this data will no longer be needed as part of any analysis. Electronic data will be overwritten/securely deleted.Paper based data will be confidentially shredded
- Participants taking part in this research will complete and sign
    - A participant information sheet (template available at the end of this form)
    - An informed consent sheet (template available available at the end of this form)

For projects involving the development, deployment and/or use of AI based systems you confirm:

- Users interacting with any AI system will be utilising dummy data provided by the student investigators
- You confirm that you understand the abilities/limitations and risks associated with the AI system/technique
- You have taken appropriate measures to avoid bias in input data and algorithm design and have documented them.
- You confirm that respect for fundamental rights and Freedoms (e.g. human autonomy, privacy and data protection) will be ensured;
- You have taken appropriate steps to mitigate potential ethical risks and have put in place risk mitigation measures in line with those detailed in the information sheet.
- You confirm that the AI based system/technique does not stigmatise or discriminate against individuals (e.g. based on sex, race, ethnic or social origin, age, genetic features, disability, sexual orientation, language, religion or belief, membership to a political group, or membership to a national minority).
- You confirm that the AI system/technique does not replace or influence human decision making processes (e.g. issues affecting human life, health, well-being or human rights, or economic, social or political decisions)
- You confirm that the AI system/technique AI system/technique does not have the potential to lead to negative social (e.g. on democracy, media, labour market, freedoms, educational choices, mass surveillance) and/or environmental impacts either through intended applications or plausible alternative uses.
- You confirm that the AI system/technique does not raise any other ethical issues not covered by this form (e.g. subliminal, covert or deceptive AI, AI that is used to stimulate addictive behaviours, life-like humanoid robots etc.)

Signed Declaration

By submitting this form, the applicants agree to the following:

The information contained herein is, to the best of my knowledge and belief, accurate. I have read the University's current research ethics guidelines, and accept responsibility for the conduct of the procedures set out in the attached application in accordance with the form

guidelines, the REC guidance and resources, the University's Conflict of Interest Policy, its Code of Good Research Practice and any other condition laid down by the Dublin City University Research Ethics Committee. I have attempted to identify all risks related to the research that may arise in conducting this research and acknowledge my obligations and the rights of the participants.

I also acknowledge my requirement to be informed as to other duties and legal obligations applying to my research, and to comply with these duties and obligations – this includes being informed about DCU Data Protection guidelines for researchers, DCU Child Protection policy and procedures (where relevant) and DCU Insurance requirements.

I and my co-investigators and/or supporting staff have the appropriate qualifications, experience and facilities to conduct the research set out in the attached application and to deal with any emergencies and contingencies related to the research that may arise. Research will not commence until required consents and approvals are in place.

I hereby declare that I will comply with data protection legislation requirements, including implementing the data protection principles, policies and practices set out above and those set out in the Data Protection Unit's web pages, to ensure data protection legislative compliance, and to protect the privacy and security of the personal data of the data subject(s) participating in this project.

Student(s) signature(s): Tadhg Donnelly Gavin Szumlicki

Print Name(s) here: Tadhg Donnelly , Gavin Szumlicki

Date: 09/02/2026

Participant Information Sheet

Please complete all sections highlighted in red.

Identify the researcher names and titles, the DCU school they are from, and title of the research study. Details of any external funding should be included on the PIS where relevant.

What is this research about?

As part of our undergraduate project Caddie, we have developed an application to aid onboarding and improve professional documentation workflows by letting users store

information in one place and quickly find cited answers to their questions . We are seeking to perform user testing of our application to gather feedback on how it may be improved.

Why is this research being conducted?
This research is being conducted as part of our project module. We seek to perform user testing to gather feedback on our developed application.

Why have you been invited to take part?
You have been invited to participate as a user to gather feedback on our developed application.

What will happen if you decide to take part in this research study?
If you decide to take part in this study, you will be presented with a brief overview of the application and asked to complete a series of steps in order. You will be provided with dummy test data to enter into the application to avoid the collection of personal data.

Once the evaluation of the application is complete you will be asked to complete an anonymous survey detailing your experience and any feedback you may have on how the application may be improved.

How will your data be used?

- The Data Controllers for this research are the student researchers, Tadhg Donnelly and Gavin Szumlicki, and all data will be processed on a personal computer, with no sharing with external data processors or non-DCU parties. Additionally, your data will not be transferred outside of Ireland.
- For any data protection concerns, you may contact the DCU Data Protection Officer, Mr. Martin Ward, at data.protection@dcu.ie or by phone at 7005118 / 7008257.
- The data is being processed solely to gather feedback on a prototype application for a final year project at DCU.
- We will not be collecting any personally identifiable information (PII); the user session will use dummy data, and the post-session survey is completely anonymous.
- The data will be securely retained for the duration of the project before being permanently deleted. This will be no later than the first day of teaching for semester one following that date on this form. . The data will not be used for any future further research.
- As a data subject, you have the right to access, rectify, or object to the processing of any data we hold on you. Please contact Tadhg Donnelly or Gavin Szumlicki at tadhg.donnelly6@mail.dcu.ie or gavin.szumlicki2@mail.dcu.ie to exercise these rights, or you may contact the DCU Data Protection Unit directly (data.protection@dcu.ie). You also have the right to lodge a complaint with the Irish Data Protection Commission (DPC). The data from this study will not be used for any future research, and all collected feedback will be anonymized for analysis and reporting, ensuring your identity cannot be linked to your responses.

Use of Artificial intelligence

This application may use Artificial Intelligence (AI), a type of technology which is used to automate decision making and/or generate new data (e.g. dialogue, images etc.). These systems are “trained” to make decisions and/or generate data based on datasets which are created by humans. These systems can pose risks to people as they can be biased in both the data they are trained on and in the way they are designed. Where a system has been designed by the student researchers, training and evaluation data will be designed such that bias that affects humans is measured and prevented during development and evaluation. However, it is still always possible that systems can be biased in unforeseen ways and lead to unequal treatment of users. In order to minimise the effects of this bias and prevent these systems from making decisions about you personally, “dummy” (fake) data will be provided to you which you will use to interact with these AI systems. This will protect your data, privacy and ensure your rights and freedoms are not affected by these systems. Though the student researchers make every effort to prevent you from experiencing harmful output from AI systems, these systems may have unexpected output. It is therefore important to emphasise that you may withdraw from this study at any time, for any reason.

How will your privacy be protected (including any legal limits to confidentiality)?

- All electronic data will be stored on a secure Google Drive only accessible to the researchers.
- Please note that confidentiality of information can only be protected within the limitations of the law - i.e., it is possible for data to be subject to subpoena, freedom of information claim or mandated reporting by some professions

What are the benefits of taking part in this research study?

There are no direct or indirect benefits to you taking part in this study

What are the risks of taking part in this research study?

The purpose of this study is to conduct user testing and gather feedback of an application. As such we do not envisage the risks posed by this work would be greater than that of using any application in a standard day-to-day setting.

Can you change your mind at any stage and withdraw from this study?

Your participation in this study is completely voluntary. You have the right to withdraw your consent to participate at any point without giving a reason and without penalty. If you choose to withdraw, your participation will end at that point. With regard to your data, any data collected up to the point of your withdrawal will be removed from the study, provided it has not yet been anonymized or used in a published report. To withdraw your consent or to request the removal of your data, please contact the student researcher using the contact details provided in this information sheet.

How will you find out what happens with this project?

If you would like to know what happens with this project or f you have any questions you can contact the researchers at: tadhg.donnelly6@mail.dcu.ie , gavin.szumlicki2@mail.dcu.ie

If participants have concerns about this study and wish to contact an independent person, please contact: The Secretary, Dublin City University Research Ethics Committee, c/o Research and Innovation Support, Dublin City University, Dublin 9. Tel 01-7008000, e-mail rec@dcu.ie

Informed Consent

Please complete all sections highlighted in red.

- Caddie - Documentation and Onboarding Assistant
- DCU School of Computing
- Principal Investigators: Tadhg Donnelly, Gavin Szumlicki
- Project Supervisor: Boualem Benatallah

I acknowledge that I have been informed of the purpose of this research, which is to gather and analyze user experience feedback for the final year project at DCU. I understand that the student researchers, Tadhg Donnelly and Gavin Szumlicki, are the Data Controllers for this study and that any personal data collected will be processed solely for the purposes described in the Participant Information Sheet. I consent to my data being used for the stated purposes.

I confirm that I have been made aware of the requirements of this study, which include participating in a user testing session followed by completing a brief anonymous survey,

Participant – please complete the following (Circle Yes or No for each question)

I have read the Participant Information Sheet (or had it read to me)	Yes/No
I understand the information provided	Yes/No
I have had an opportunity to ask questions and discuss this study	Yes/No
I have received satisfactory answers to all my questions	Yes/No
I understand the information provided	Yes/No
I confirm that I am at least 18 years of age*	Yes/No

I understand that my participation is voluntary and that I may withdraw from the survey at any time by closing the page without clicking on “Submit” Yes/No

- I confirm that I may withdraw from this study at any point
- I understand that all information I provide for this study will be treated with the utmost confidentiality.

- I understand the arrangements made to protect confidentiality of data, and e that this confidentiality is subject to legal limitations, such as a court order or legal requirement to disclose information. The student researchers will take all reasonable steps to ensure my identity is protected.
- I understand that all data collected will be destroyed at the end of the project

Signature:

I have read and understood the information in this form. My questions and concerns have been answered by the researchers, and I have a copy of this consent form. Therefore, I consent to take part in this research project

Participants Signature:

_____

Name in Block Capitals:

_____

Witness:

_____

Date:

_____

Survey Questions

Please list the questions you will be asking in your survey here. If you are using Google Forms (or other survey software) please place screenshots of the survey questions.

1. What are you hoping Caddie helps you do?
2. What, if anything, felt confusing about the initial set up?
3. How easy was it to create a new hub?
4. How easy was it to create a new source?
5. Did the system response to uploading a new source match what you expected?
6. For the previous question, if no, why?
7. For the provided onboarding scenario, how helpful was the generated guide?
8. For the provided onboarding scenario, how accurate were the FAQs and answers?
9. How accurate were the suggested reminders?
10. How happy were you with chat response times?
11. How confident were you in chat responses?

12. For the previous question, why?
13. How accurate were chat citations?
14. Did chat citations make you feel that you could confidently verify where an answer came from? Why?
15. What was the most useful part of the application?
16. What was the least useful part of the application?
17. If you could change one thing about the application, what would it be?
18. How likely would you be to integrate Caddie into your documentation workflows?
19. Is there any feature you expected that wasn't there?
20. Were there any aspects of the User Interface that felt unintuitive or not immediately obvious?

Caddie User Testing

User testing for the Caddie

What are you hoping Caddie helps you do? *

Short-answer text

What, if anything, felt confusing about the initial set up?

Long-answer text

How easy was it to create a new hub? *

	1	2	3	4	5	
Difficult	○	○	○	○	○	Easy

How easy was it to create a new source? *

	1	2	3	4	5	
Difficult	○	○	○	○	○	Easy

Did the system response to uploading a new source match what you expected? *

- ◯ Yes
- ◯ No

For the previous question, if no, why?

Long-answer text

For the provided onboarding scenario, how helpful was the generated guide? *

	1	2	3	4	5	
Highly unhelpful	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	Highly helpful

For the provided onboarding scenario, how accurate were the FAQs and answers? *

	1	2	3	4	5	
Highly unhelpful	◯	◯	◯	◯	◯	Highly helpful

How accurate were the suggested reminders? *

	1	2	3	4	5	
Highly inaccurate	○	○	○	○	○	Highly accurate

How happy were you with chat response times? *

	1	2	3	4	5	
Unhappy	○	○	○	○	○	Happy

How confident were you in chat responses? *

	1	2	3	4	5	
Highly unconfident	○	○	○	○	○	Highly confident

For the previous question, why? *

Long-answer text

How accurate were chat citations? *

	1	2	3	4	5	
Highly inaccurate	○	○	○	○	○	Highly accurate

Did chat citations make you feel that you could confidently verify where an answer came from? Why? *

Long-answer text

What was the most useful part of the application? *

Short-answer text

What was the least useful part of the application? *

Short-answer text

If you could change one thing about the application, what would it be? *

Long-answer text

How likely would you be to integrate Caddie into your documentation workflows? *

	1	2	3	4	5	
Unlikely	○	○	○	○	○	Likely

Is there any feature you expected that wasn't there? *

Short-answer text

Were there any aspects of the User Interface that felt unintuitive or not immediately obvious?

Long-answer text